

**Committee:** Historical Security Council (HSC)  
**Topic:** The Cuban Missile Crisis: Preventing Nuclear War, 1962  
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**Freeze Date:** 22 October 1962

## Introduction

The Cold War created an intense political and military rivalry between two of the biggest powers, the United States and the Soviet Union. Both powers aimed to develop their expansion of nuclear arsenals, in order to expand their influence while trying to avoid direct contact with one another. The increasing development of nuclear arsenals made this rivalry even more dangerous as it could lead to a nuclear war. In October of 1962, Soviet nuclear missile installations were found in Cuba, around 90 miles away from the United States. The Soviet Union and Cuba argued that their military cooperation was necessary for Cuba's security, and to keep balance in power. The United States considers the nuclear missiles to be a direct threat to its national security.

The international community must therefore find solutions to deescalate the situation while addressing the security concerns of all parties involved.

## Key Words

*Nuclear weapon/missile* - an explosive device that gets its destructive force from nuclear reactions, developed during WWII in an operation called the "Manhattan Project".

*Cold War* - The long period of political, economic, and military tension between the United States and the Soviet Union, following the Second World War.

*Nuclear Deterrence* - The military strategy of discouraging an enemy from attacking by holding the ability to retaliate with nuclear weapons.

*Mutually Assured Destruction (MAD)* - The idea that a nuclear attack by one country would start a full scale nuclear retaliation, becoming extremely costly for both sides.

*Bay of Pigs Invasion* - the failed invasion of Cuba by Cuban exiles, backed by the CIA, intended to overthrow Fidel Castro's government on April 17, 1961.

*NATO* - The North Atlantic Treaty Organization, an international military alliance including the United States and multiple western countries.

*Warsaw Pact* - A military alliance composed of several communist states in Eastern Europe, led by the Soviet Union.

## General Overview

Following the Second World War, the United States and the Soviet Union emerged as two dominant powers. The period of their political and military rivalry was known as the Cold War. During that time, there were two bloc's, the Western bloc being led by the United States, and the Eastern bloc being led by the Soviet Union. By 1962, both powers had expanded their nuclear arsenal, which made direct confrontation between them extremely dangerous, as an attack by either side could end up leading to an all out nuclear war.

The relations between Cuba and the United States worsened, after the Cuban Revolution of 1959 where Fidel Castro was brought to power. Cuba became a major point of tension during the Cold War, as their relations with the Soviet Union became closer, and the United States became increasingly more concerned about having Soviet influence so close to American territory. The growing tension led to the failed Bay of Pigs invasion of Cuba by Cuban exiles backed by the United States in April 1961, where they sought to overthrow Fidel Castro's government. The failed invasion of Cuba, increased Cuba's fear of another attack from the United States, which strengthened their military cooperation with the Soviet Union. In 1962, the Soviet Union secretly started deploying nuclear capable ballistic missiles to Cuba. The Soviet Union viewed this as protection for Cuba and gaining better strategic positions against the United States, which possessed nuclear forces that were capable of striking the Soviet Union, stationed in Turkey.

The crisis escalated in October of 1962 when photographs taken by an American Lockheed U-2 plane showed Soviet Union installations under construction in Cuba. President John F. Kennedy and his advisors considered many actions to take like diplomatic negotiations, naval blockades,

air strikes, or an invasion of Cuba. On 22 October 1962, John F. Kennedy publicly announced the presence of Soviet weapons in Cuba, demanded their removal and announced a naval “quarantine” to prevent any more military equipment getting into Cuba. The United States viewed the presence of missiles in Cuba as a national security threat, while Cuba remained fearful of an invasion by the United States. The Soviet Union faced pressure to remove their military presence from the island. As of the freeze date of October 22 1962, the conflict remains unsolved leaving the international community with the task of deescalating the situation while keeping in mind the safety of all states involved.

## Major Parties Involved

*The United States of America* - Led by John F. Kennedy, the USA views the presence of Soviet forces in Cuba as a threat to its national security.

*The Soviet Union* - Led by Nikita Khrushchev, the Soviet Union deployed nuclear capable weapons in Cuba and viewed it as protection for Cuba and a strategic position during the Cold War.

*Cuba* - Led by Fidel Castro, Cuba has established military cooperation with the Soviet Union, and fears an invasion from the USA.

*United Nations (UN)* - International Council in which peaceful discussions and possible solutions can be discussed, and where resolutions can be reached.

## Timeline of Relevant Events

| Year            | Event                                                                                                      |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1959            | Cuban Revolution brings Fidel Castro to power. Relations with the United States begin to deteriorate.      |
| 17 April 1961   | The Bay of Pigs invasion by U.S.-backed Cuban exiles fails, increasing Cuba’s fear of another U.S. attack. |
| 3 February 1962 | The United States’ trade embargo against Cuba takes effect, deepening the political and economic conflict. |

|                       |                                                                                                                            |
|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| August - October 1962 | The Soviet Union secretly sends military personnel and equipment, including nuclear-capable missiles, to Cuba.             |
| 14 October 1962       | A U-2 reconnaissance flight photographs Soviet missile sites under construction in Cuba.                                   |
| 16 October 1962       | President Kennedy is informed of the photographs. He convenes senior advisers, later called ExComm, to consider responses. |
| 20 October 1962       | Kennedy chooses a naval “quarantine” as an initial step while keeping diplomatic and military options under review.        |
| 22 October 1962       | Kennedy announces the missile sites and the quarantine in a televised address to the American public.                      |
| 22 October 1962       | The United States requests an emergency Security Council meeting; Cuba also submits a complaint to the Council.            |
| 22 October 1962       | Freeze date: the crisis remains unresolved, and delegates must seek a peaceful response before the situation escalates     |

## Relevant Documents

### *Document 1: Kennedy’s televised address (22 October 1962)*

Kennedy explains the U.S. claim that Soviet missile sites in Cuba threaten the Western Hemisphere and announces a naval quarantine; delegates can use it to understand the U.S. position and proposed action.

### *Document 2: Cuba’s letter to the Security Council (22 October 1962)*

Cuba’s complaint presents its view of the crisis and its security concerns. It gives delegates a primary-source account to weigh alongside the U.S. statement.

## Possible Solutions

1. *Freeze the military build-up.* Call for an immediate pause in missile-site construction and further offensive-weapons deliveries while negotiations begin.
2. *Prevent an accidental clash at sea.* Keep a temporary quarantine in place with clear identification and communication rules; require ships and aircraft to avoid provocation or firing unless attacked.
3. *Use UN mediation and verification.* Ask the Secretary-General to mediate and propose inspections in Cuba only with Cuban agreement, alongside reciprocal steps that address Cuba's fear of invasion.
4. *Negotiate reciprocal security guarantees.* Seek a written U.S. pledge not to invade Cuba in exchange for verified removal of offensive missiles and a commitment that no new ones will be introduced

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